



This document outlines the estimated monthly and annual costs to host the AEF HRM System for an enterprise-level demo of 50 staff members. All USD amounts are converted at 1 USD = 600 XAF (indicative rate). The recommended stack uses Railway (hosting + database), Resend (email), and a custom domain.

1. CORE HOSTING COSTS (Recommended: Railway)

Component	Plan	USD/mo	XAF/mo	XAF/year	Notes
Web Server (App)	Railway Hobby	\$5.00	3,000	36,000	Includes \$5 free credit
PostgreSQL DB	Railway Starter	\$5.00	3,000	36,000	1 GB RAM, sufficient for 50 users
SSL Certificate	Auto (Let's Encrypt)	FREE	FREE	FREE	Included with Railway
Static Files CDN	WhiteNoise (built-in)	FREE	FREE	FREE	Already configured in the app
HOSTING SUBTOTAL		\$10.00	6,000	72,000	

2. EMAIL SERVICE (Notifications, Onboarding, Password Reset)

Component	Plan	USD/mo	XAF/mo	XAF/year	Notes
Resend Email	Free Tier	FREE	FREE	FREE	3,000 emails/mo — enough for 50 staff
Resend Email	Pro (if needed)	\$20.00	12,000	144,000	50,000 emails/mo (only if you exceed free)
EMAIL SUBTOTAL (recommended)		FREE	FREE	FREE	3,000 emails/mo is sufficient

3. DOMAIN NAME (Optional but Recommended)

Component	Plan	USD/mo	XAF/mo	XAF/year	Notes
Custom Domain (.com)	Namecheap / GoDaddy	\$1.00	600	7,200	e.g. aef-hrm.com (first year ~\$1)
Custom Domain (.com)	Renewal year 2+	\$12.00	7,200	8,640	~\$12/year standard renewal
Without domain	Railway subdomain	FREE	FREE	FREE	e.g. aef-hrm.up.railway.app

4. TOTAL COST SUMMARY

Scenario	USD/mo	XAF/mo	XAF/year	Recommendation
Option A — No domain (Railway subdomain)	\$10.00	6,000	72,000	Minimum to start demo
Option B — With .com domain (year 1)	\$10.83	6,500	79,200	Professional, branded URL
Option C — Full pro (domain + email Pro)	\$30.83	18,500	222,000	High-volume notifications
RECOMMENDED FOR 50-STAFF DEMO	\$10.00	6,000	72,000	Option A — simple & reliable

5. STEP-BY-STEP: WHAT YOU NEED TO DO

Step 1 Create Railway Account

Go to railway.app → Sign up with GitHub → Create a new project → Deploy from GitHub repo (44bryan/Leave-System). Railway auto-detects Django.



Step 2 Add PostgreSQL Database

In Railway dashboard → Add Plugin → PostgreSQL. Railway sets DATABASE_URL automatically. Run migrations via Railway shell: `python manage.py migrate`

Step 3 Set Environment Variables

In Railway → Variables, add: SECRET_KEY, DEBUG=False, ALLOWED_HOSTS=*.up.railway.app, RESEND_API_KEY (from resend.com free account), DEFAULT_FROM_EMAIL

Step 4 Collect Static Files

Add start command in Railway: `python manage.py collectstatic --noinput && gunicorn leave_system.wsgi`. Static files served by WhiteNoise (already configured).

Step 5 Create Superuser & Staff Accounts

Use Railway shell → `python manage.py createsuperuser`. Then log in at /admin/ and create the 50 employee accounts. Assign roles: HR, supervisor, CEO, etc.

Step 6 (Optional) Custom Domain

Buy .com domain on Namecheap (~\$1 first year). In Railway → Settings → Custom Domain → point DNS CNAME to Railway URL. SSL auto-applies in ~5 minutes.

6. RAILWAY PLAN COMPARISON

Feature	Free	Hobby (\$5/mo)	Pro (\$20/mo)	Verdict
RAM	512 MB	512 MB	8 GB	Hobby fine for 50 staff
CPU	Shared	Shared	Shared	Shared is enough
Sleep on idle	YES ■	No	No	Must use Hobby or higher
Custom domain	No	Yes	Yes	Needed for branding
PostgreSQL	Included	\$5 add-on	\$5 add-on	Add \$5 for DB
Support	Community	Community	Priority	Community OK for demo
RECOMMENDED	—	✓ YES	—	Hobby + PG = \$10/mo

FINAL RECOMMENDATION: For the 50-staff enterprise demo, subscribe to Railway Hobby Plan (\$5/month) + Railway PostgreSQL add-on (\$5/month). Total = \$10/month = approximately 6,000 XAF/month or 72,000 XAF/year. No other payments are required to run the full system including leave management, appraisals, contracts, discipline, notifications, and PDF generation. Use the free Railway subdomain (e.g. aef-hrm.up.railway.app) for the demo. If the demo is successful and you want a professional branded URL, add a .com domain for ~7,200 XAF/year.